

S04-P — The Final Simulation: The Proof Each Client Asks For

Summary. This handout closes the course "Selling Modern and Contemporary Art in New York" with the applied synthesis of the final practice, a fair simulation in which an advisor handles three simultaneous conversations, each built on material already covered across the four preceding weeks. The thread connecting them is a single principle, every client objection asks for a specific kind of proof rather than a restatement of the advisor's own judgment, and that principle is documented here through the three cases that anchor the day's script, building a price pitch on dated comparables, using aggregate return data to ease resale anxiety, and the contractual mechanics of a consignment without complete provenance.

1. The pitch under a price objection: the Varejão case

Brazilian painter Adriana Varejão has spent more than three decades building a body of work in glazed ceramic that references Brazil's colonial history. Her historical auction record, set in 2011, describes an exceptional transaction from more than a decade ago, made under market conditions that no longer hold. The defensible price argument for 2026 rests instead on recent, dated comparables, [Phillips London sold *Monocromo Redondo Ge* for USD 374,100 on June 8, 2026](#),¹ and thirteen days earlier, [Phillips New York had placed *Monocromo redondo Guan* for USD 361,200 on May 21, 2026](#).² The two results, achieved in different cities and in different sessions of the same house, fall within an eleven-thousand-dollar band of each other, and that agreement between two independent observations is what turns an isolated data point into a defensible pattern against the objection that a work "is expensive." A verifiable timing argument reinforces the price case, [Varejão is representing Brazil at the 2026 Venice Biennale](#), the most closely watched contemporary art exhibition on the international annual calendar.³ The case also illustrates a second course principle, that a strong pitch invites comparison with other auction houses rather than avoiding it, because a price objection resolved with evidence leaves the client better positioned to seek a second opinion without weakening the relationship with the advisor.

2. Aggregate return evidence against resale anxiety

A second type of objection centers on the fear of having made a mistake at purchase, more than on the price of any one work. Week two's lesson already established that a single isolated auction result does not amount to a sustained trend, through the contrast between two Phillips artists, [Derek Fordjour set his own auction record with *Twelve Tribes*, hammered at USD 1,143,000 on November 19, 2024, twenty percent above the previous record of USD 945,000 set at Christie's in May 2022,⁴](#) while [Firelei Báez reached USD 645,000 at Phillips on November 19, 2025, only for Christie's to surpass that result the same day with USD 1.11 million for another of her works,](#) with no second Báez result yet confirming that level as sustained.⁵ Fordjour has repeated his price across two houses and two years, Báez has not yet, and that difference is exactly what separates a standing benchmark from an isolated outlier. Faced with a client's question about buying with resale in mind, the relevant data point is aggregate market evidence, ahead of any single artist's individual trajectory, [the joint Bank of America and ArtTactic study for 2026 found an average annual return of eleven percent on works held between twenty and twenty five years, against negative five point seven percent on those sold before five years.⁶](#) The report itself warns that this kind of repeat-sales data can suffer from selection and survivorship bias, and under no circumstance amounts to a forecast for a specific work, a caveat the advisor has to deliver alongside the figure and not afterward.

3. The contractual mechanics of a consignment without complete provenance

The third conversation in the simulation deals with a different problem, a client who has inherited a work and ranks its final destination above any urgency to sell. Here the proof required is procedural rather than a matter of price. [Sotheby's publishes a standard seller's commission of ten percent of the hammer price, with a five hundred dollar minimum, plus an additional two percent success fee when the result exceeds the agreed high estimate,](#) while [Christie's negotiates that commission case by case according to the value and category of the work,](#) an approach Phillips shares in practice.^{7 8} Guarantees, a price floor underwritten by the house itself or shared with a third party, are reserved almost exclusively for higher-visibility, higher-value lots, and do not extend to a piece without a recent resale history or complete provenance documentation. The case draws on [Jesús Rafael Soto as its market reference, whose auction record remains *La Scie à Métaux*, hammered at Sotheby's New York on November 19, 2012 for USD 1,082,500,](#) the highest price ever paid for one of his works to date, although a 2012 record does not by itself describe the current market for a piece lacking provenance or recent evidence.⁹ The choice of house for a consignment of this kind is not arbitrary either, [Sotheby's closed 2025 with consolidated sales](#)

[of USD 7 billion, a figure equivalent to roughly seven and a half times the USD 927 million in global sales Phillips reported the same year](#), and that scale gap, already covered in the course's first week, explains why a family consignment of this size tends to land with one of the two larger houses.¹⁰

For the conversation with clients

Three concrete applications summarize the simulation. First, when facing the objection that a work is expensive, the professional response consists of a second dated comparable confirming the first, rather than a restatement of the advisor's own judgment. Second, when asked whether a work will appreciate, it is worth separating clearly what an aggregate market average shows from what can be promised about one specific piece, and naming that distinction out loud to the client. Third, with a client who ranks a work's final destination above its price, the conversation is resolved with the exact contractual terms, commission, reserve, and the absence of a guarantee, ahead of any value estimate that does not yet have sufficient support.

Sources

1. HENI News, market profile of Adriana Varejão, Phillips London result of 2026-06-08. [HENI](#). ↵
2. Phillips, *Modern & Contemporary Art Afternoon Sale*, New York, 2026-05-21, lot by Adriana Varejão, *Monocromo redondo Guan*, USD 361,200. [Phillips](#). ↵
3. La Biennale di Venezia, 2026 art edition. [La Biennale di Venezia](#). ↵
4. HENI, "Derek Fordjour, Twelve Tribes," November 19, 2024, and Phillips, artist page for Derek Fordjour. [HENI](#) · [Phillips](#). ↵
5. HENI, "Firelei Báez, Untitled, Colonization in America," November 20, 2025, and Phillips, artist page for Firelei Báez. [HENI](#) · [Phillips](#). ↵
6. Bank of America and ArtTactic, *U.S. Art Market Report 2026*, annualized return by holding period. [Bank of America](#). ↵
7. Sotheby's, "Buy & Sell at Sotheby's." [Sotheby's](#). ↵
8. Christie's, "Financial Information." [Christie's](#). ↵
9. Sotheby's, "Jesús Rafael Soto | Art for Sale, Results & Biography." [Sotheby's](#). ↵

10. Phillips, global results release (2025-12-18), and Sotheby's, "Sotheby's Projects 2025 Consolidated Sales of \$7 Billion" (2025-12-17). [Phillips](#) · [Sotheby's](#). ↵